

# Digitale Arkiver & Metoder Portfolio

## RegEx & OpenRefine

**Task 1: List regex that extracts dates from <http://bit.ly/regexexercise2> and formats them as YYYY-MM-DD?**

URL for the solution: <https://regex101.com/r/A0UC0D/2>

### **Brief explanation:**

The regex used is: `(\d{1,2}).(\d{1,2}). ?(\d{4})`

Through the (parenthesis) we've grouped each part of the date which is in the original text in the format: Month, Day, Year. The `\d` catches digits while the {curly brackets} specify the amount of numbers in it. The `.` and `?` are there to catch numbers spaced oddly or split by comma.

The substitution used is: `{ $3 } { $1 } { $2 }`

Here we simply reorganize the groupings we've already defined into the proper year, month, day format as asked. Thus we have our solution.

### **Task 2 Regex to convert stopwordslist between R and Voyant format**

**R to Voyant:** Our Regex is: `^c\(|\)|$|",\s*` and our Substitution is: `\n`

### **Brief explanation:**

The regex subsequently catches the commas, quotations and spaces while leaving the words untouched. Then substituting with `\n` we create a newline and create a stoplist suited for Voyant.

**Voyant to R:** Our Regex is `\n` and our substitution is `" , "`

### **Brief explanation:**

The regex being a plain `\n` catches each new line while leaving the words untouched. Our substitution simply wraps each word in a quotation and separates them by commas. Using this method one will have to manually add a quotation at the start of the very first word and at the end of the very last word. However this is a small task that does not take much time.

### **Task 3 Does OpenRefine alter the raw data during sorting and filtering?**

It does not.

#### **Task 4: What are the two most water-deprived months in Mozambique and Tanzania?**

We edit the data. Transforming the cells with: `value.replace("[", "").replace("]", "").replace("'", "")` to unify the cells and remove unwanted quotations and brackets. Giving us a cleaner list. We also do: `value.replace(" ", "")` to remove spaces since otherwise they'll count "Oct" and " Oct" as two separate entities. Having this final list we can conclude that the two most water-deprived months are: October (74) and September (70).

#### **Task 5: Challenge - 10 most common occupations among ..... in [1801 Aarhus](#)**

- Total number of people in your selected cohort: 3311, I have focused on men.
- Define what is / is not an occupation:

I have gone from the principle that an occupation is their primary source of income.

The following list is based on men in the age of 20-30

#### **10 most frequent occupations by the numbers:**

1. Soldat (389)
2. Bonde og gaardbeboer (117)
3. Tjenestekarl (37)
4. Væver (27)
5. Huusmand med jord (22)
6. Gårdskarl (11)
7. Gaardmand (10)
8. Land recrut (10)
9. Læredreng (10)

## Tidy Spreadsheets and the Danish Succession

This week we began working on spreadsheets.

The goal was to create a tidy spreadsheet listing the names of Danish monarchs. This had to include their birth- and death-year and the start and end of their reign.

Under the submitted assignment you will find the file: 'Danish Monarchy'. This is the spreadsheet created. In it you will find each Danish monarch, their birth- and death-years as well as the years they reigned. The odd monarch has a note attached to them that explains any oddity regarding their reign. (For example the King who ruled twice.)

This spreadsheet was made entirely by hand whilst crossexamining the sources we'd been given. This being the website we were recommended. It can be found [here](#).

The spreadsheet itself has been uploaded alongside this document.

Additionally you will find the script for how to achieve similar results further below.

### **What are the basic principles for using spreadsheets for good data organisation?**

There are a few guiding principles when creating a spreadsheet that one can adhere to in order to create a tidy and organised dataset. Firstly let's discuss **Multivalued Attributing**. Excel cells typically only handle one value. (EG: "Blue" and "Red" rather than "Blue, Red") To create a tidy dataset it is recommended to keep cell values at one. Additionally **Consistency is Key**, make sure to have consistent cell values. (EG: "No." should be "No" the entire way through. Not "no" or "N" or other such examples.) In the "messy" example we were shown we also took note of multiple tables per worksheet, this might confuse programs like **R** and thus one worksheet should hold one table. If we come across missing data do not use "0" but rather "NA" without the slash. As was said in class: **ambiguity is our biggest enemy**. Furthermore, consistency and completeness of data can be improved through **Data Validation**. The function found in Excel allows you to set certain parameters, such as defining what data is 'allowed' in a section. Thereby we can create a list of accepted terms and the spreadsheet will inherently reject any cells filled with terms that are not on said list. When you have a well made spreadsheet you can export the data to formats like **CSV** or **TSV**, allowing it to be used consistently by most programs. Thus we can also take **CSV** files and convert them into readable spreadsheets. It is important to note that being Europeans with predominantly European operating systems we use the **CSV2** format.

# Monarch

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2026-08-03

```
#First we activate the needed packages.
```

```
library(dplyr)
```

```
##
```

```
## Attaching package: 'dplyr'
```

```
## The following objects are masked from 'package:stats':
```

```
##
```

```
## filter, lag
```

```
## The following objects are masked from 'package:base':
```

```
##
```

```
## intersect, setdiff, setequal, union
```

```
library(magrittr)
```

```
library(knitr)
```

```
library(tidyverse)
```

```
## -- Attaching core tidyverse packages ----- tidyverse 2.0.0 --
```

```
## v forcats 1.0.1 v readr 2.2.0
```

```
## v ggplot2 4.0.3 v stringr 1.6.0
```

```
## v lubridate 1.9.5 v tibble 3.3.1
```

```
## v purrr 1.2.2 v tidyr 1.3.2
```

```
## -- Conflicts ----- tidyverse_conflicts() --
```

```
## x tidyr::extract() masks magrittr::extract()
```

```
## x dplyr::filter() masks stats::filter()
```

```
## x dplyr::lag() masks stats::lag()
```

```
## x purrr::set_names() masks magrittr::set_names()
```

```
## i Use the conflicted package (<http://conflicted.r-lib.org/>) to force all conflicts to become errors
```

```
#Then we load the data.
```

```
DKmonarch <- read_csv("/Users/Aruuk/Desktop/kings.csv", na = "NULL")
```

```
## Warning: One or more parsing issues, call 'problems()' on your data frame for details,
```

```
## e.g.:
```

```
## dat <- vroom(...)
```

```
## problems(dat)
```

```
## Rows: 57 Columns: 11
## -- Column specification -----
## Delimiter: ","
## chr (7): Name, House, Gender, Dynasty, Source, BirthDMY, DeathDMY
## dbl (4): Start_year, End_year, Birth_year, Death_year
##
## i Use 'spec()' to retrieve the full column specification for this data.
## i Specify the column types or set 'show_col_types = FALSE' to quiet this message.
```

```
DKmonarch
```

```
## # A tibble: 57 x 11
##   Name      House Start_year End_year Birth_year Death_year Gender Dynasty Source
##   <chr>    <chr>      <dbl>   <dbl>   <dbl>    <dbl> <chr>  <chr>  <chr>
## 1 Gorm d~ Gorm      936     958     908     958 M      "Jelli~ https~
## 2 Harald~ Gorm      NA      NA      936     985 M      "Jelli~ https~
## 3 Toke_G~ Gorm      985     986      NA     986 M      "Jelli~ https~
## 4 Svend ~ Gorm      NA      NA      NA    1014 M      "Jelli~ https~
## 5 Harald~ Gorm     1014    1018     963      NA M      "Jelli~ https~
## 6 Knud 1~ Gorm     1018    1035      NA    1035 M      "Jelli~ https~
## 7 Hardek~ Gorm     1035    1042     995    1042 M      "Jelli~ https~
## 8 Magnus~ Fair~    1042    1047    1018    1047 M      "Jelli~ https~
## 9 Svend ~ Estr~    1047    1074    1024    1076 M      ""      https~
## 10 Harald~ Estr~    1074    1080    1019    1080 M      "Jelli~ https~
## # i 47 more rows
## # i 2 more variables: BirthDMY <chr>, DeathDMY <chr>
```

```
#We use a pipe to add a new row called duration:
```

```
DKmonarch <- DKmonarch %>%
  mutate(duration = End_year - Start_year)
```

```
library(ggplot2)
```

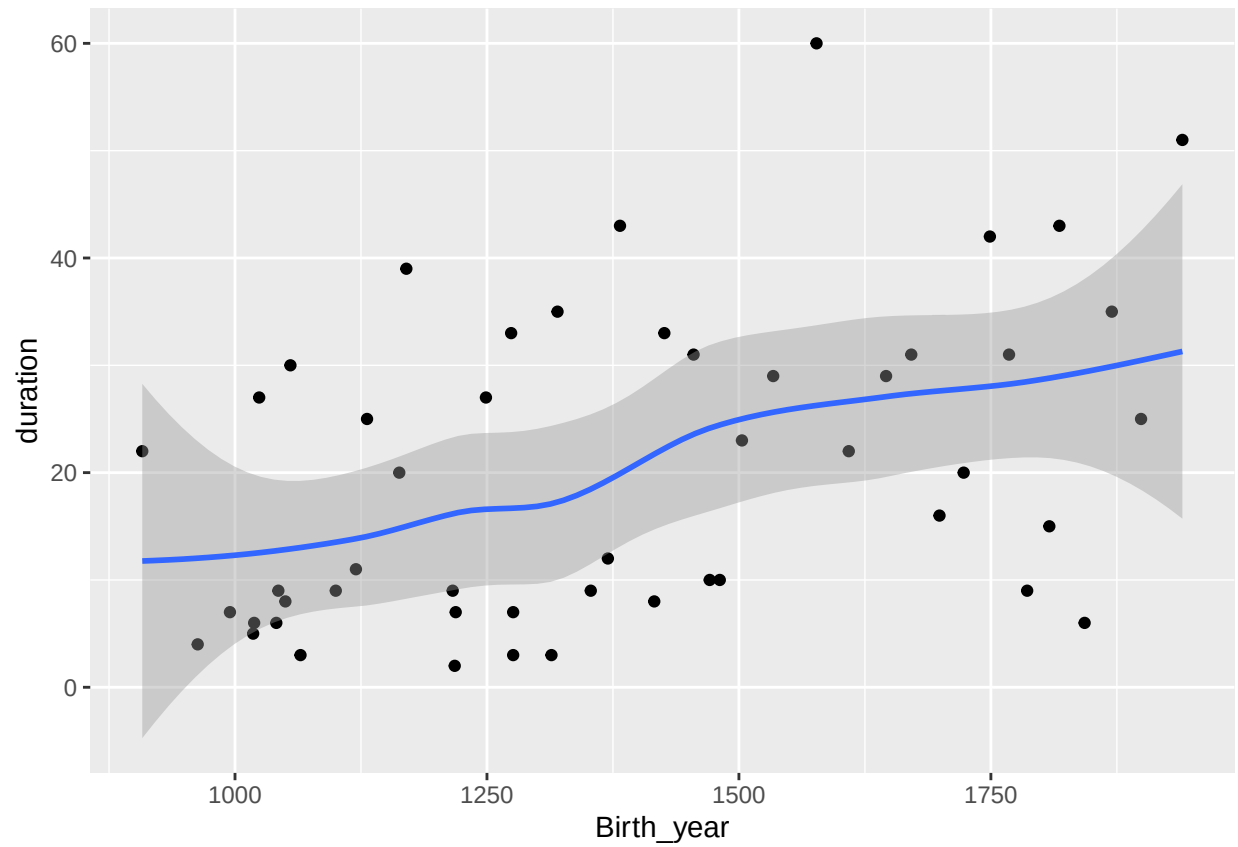
```
#We make a pipe where we plot duration on the y-axis and birth on the x-axis:
```

```
DKmonarch %>%
  ggplot(aes(x = Birth_year , y = duration)) +
  geom_point() +
  geom_smooth()
```

```
## 'geom_smooth()' using method = 'loess' and formula = 'y ~ x'
```

```
## Warning: Removed 7 rows containing non-finite outside the scale range
## ('stat_smooth()').
```

```
## Warning: Removed 7 rows containing missing values or values outside the scale range
## ('geom_point()').
```



This leave us with the obviously conclusion that the monarchs born later in the century have a longer duration time. This is obviously since the average age for a person has gotten longer throughout the centuries.

# Sentiment Analysis GOT

## Your task

Taking this script as a point of departure, apply sentiment analysis on the Game of Thrones. You will find a pdf in the data folder. What are the most common meaningful words and what emotions do you expect will dominate this volume? Are there any terms that are similarly ambiguous to the 'confidence' above?

```
library(tinytex)
```

```
#We load the file needed.
```

```
got_path <- here("data","got.pdf")  
got_text <- pdf_text(got_path)
```

```
#Through the following code we separate lines into their own rows with starting  
#and trailing spaces removed.
```

```
got_df <- data.frame(got_text) %>%  
  mutate(text_full = str_split(got_text, pattern = '\\n')) %>%  
  unnest(text_full) %>%  
  mutate(text_full = str_trim(text_full))
```

```
#Now we make tokens. (individual words)
```

```
got_tokens <- got_df %>%  
  unnest_tokens(word, text_full)
```

```
#Now we count the words numerically.
```

```
got_wc <- got_tokens %>%  
  count(word) %>%  
  arrange(-n)  
got_wc
```

```
## # A tibble: 11,826 x 2  
##   word      n  
##   <chr> <int>  
## 1 the    17988  
## 2 and     8997  
## 3 to      6640  
## 4 a       6461  
## 5 of      6200  
## 6 he      5166  
## 7 his     5161  
## 8 was     3904
```

```
## 9 her 3659
## 10 you 3267
## # i 11,816 more rows
```

*#Now we remove stop words as they give us little to work with in terms of semantics.*

```
got_stop <- got_tokens %>%
  anti_join(stop_words) %>%
  select(-got_text)
```

*#We check the count again with the stopwords now removed.*

```
got_swc <- got_stop %>%
  count(word) %>%
  arrange(-n)
```

*#Now we filter out numbers.*

```
got_no_numeric <- got_stop %>%
  filter(is.na(as.numeric(word)))
```

*#First we calculate the length. It comes out to 11209.*

```
length(unique(got_no_numeric$word))
```

```
## [1] 11209
```

*#Now we filter out to only include the top 100 most common words.*

```
got_top100 <- got_no_numeric %>%
  count(word) %>%
  arrange(-n) %>%
  head(100)
got_top100
```

```
## # A tibble: 100 x 2
##   word      n
##   <chr> <int>
## 1 lord   1341
## 2 ser    1023
## 3 jon     787
## 4 ned     743
## 5 tyrion  591
## 6 eyes    567
## 7 hand    567
## 8 king    542
## 9 father  512
## 10 told   504
## # i 90 more rows
```

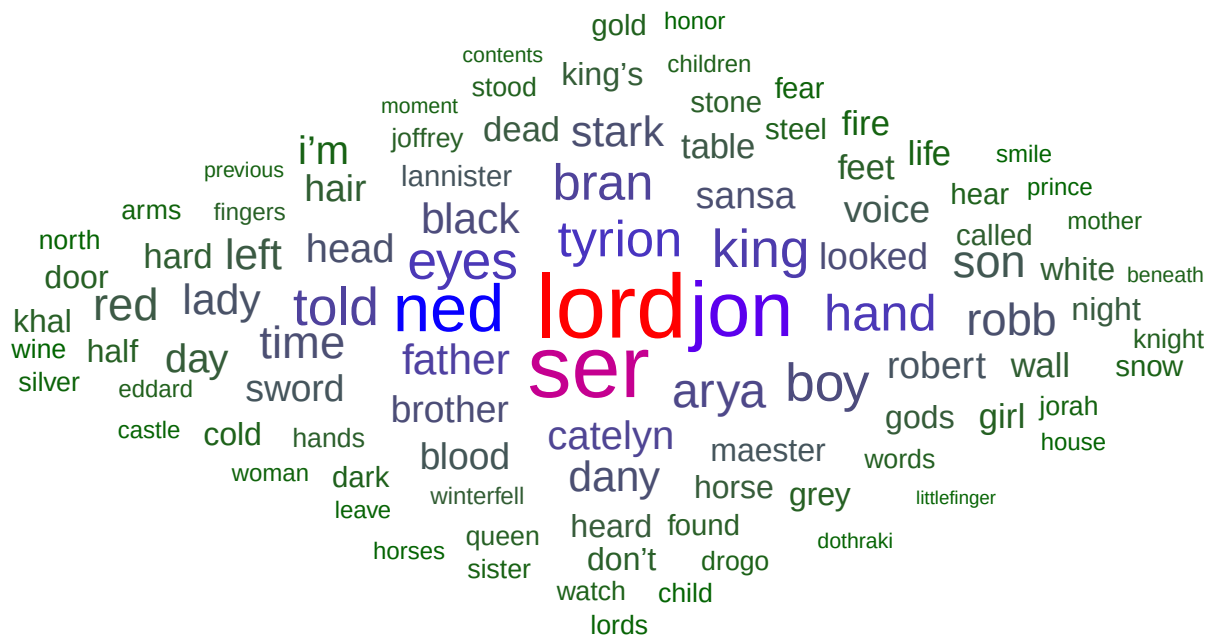
*#Now we make a ggplot.*

```
got_cloud <- ggplot(data = got_top100, aes(label = word)) +
  geom_text_wordcloud() +
  theme_minimal()
```

got\_cloud



```
#Now we customize it so it looks more aesthetic.  
ggplot(data = got_top100, aes(label = word, size = n)) +  
  geom_text_wordcloud_area(aes(color = n), shape = "diamond") +  
  scale_size_area(max_size = 20) +  
  scale_color_gradientn(colors = c("darkgreen", "blue", "red")) +  
  theme_minimal()
```



Now we proceed with the sentiment analysis.

*#Now we run the words through the ratings of most negative to most positive sentiment.*

```
get_sentiments(lexicon = "afinn")
```

```
## # A tibble: 2,477 x 2
##   word                value
##   <chr>              <dbl>
## 1 abandon             -2
## 2 abandoned           -2
## 3 abandons            -2
## 4 abducted            -2
## 5 abduction           -2
## 6 abductions          -2
## 7 abhor               -3
## 8 abhorred            -3
## 9 abhorrent           -3
## 10 abhors             -3
## # i 2,467 more rows
```

#Now we focus on the positive words.

```
afinn_pos <- get_sentiments("afinn") %>%  
  filter(value %in% c(3,4,5))
```

afinn\_pos

```
## # A tibble: 222 x 2
##   word      value
##   <chr>    <dbl>
## 1 admire      3
## 2 admired     3
## 3 admires     3
## 4 admiring    3
## 5 adorable    3
## 6 adore       3
## 7 adored      3
## 8 adores      3
## 9 affection   3
## 10 affectionate 3
## # i 212 more rows
```

*#Through the `bing` function we ascertain whether a word is positive or negative.*

```
get_sentiments(lexicon = "bing")
```

```
## # A tibble: 6,786 x 2
##   word      sentiment
##   <chr>    <chr>
## 1 2-faces  negative
## 2 abnormal negative
## 3 abolish negative
## 4 abominable negative
## 5 abominably negative
## 6 abominate negative
## 7 abomination negative
## 8 abort    negative
## 9 aborted  negative
## 10 aborts   negative
## # i 6,776 more rows
```

*#Through the `nrc` function we get more descriptive sentiments other than simply positive and negative.*

```
get_sentiments(lexicon = "nrc")
```

```
## # A tibble: 13,872 x 2
##   word      sentiment
##   <chr>    <chr>
## 1 abacus   trust
## 2 abandon  fear
## 3 abandon  negative
## 4 abandon  sadness
## 5 abandoned anger
## 6 abandoned fear
## 7 abandoned negative
## 8 abandoned sadness
## 9 abandonment anger
## 10 abandonment fear
## # i 13,862 more rows
```

*#Now we use a pipe function to bind words from got\_stop to afinn.*

```
got_afinn <- got_stop %>%  
  inner_join(get_sentiments("afinn"))  
got_afinn
```

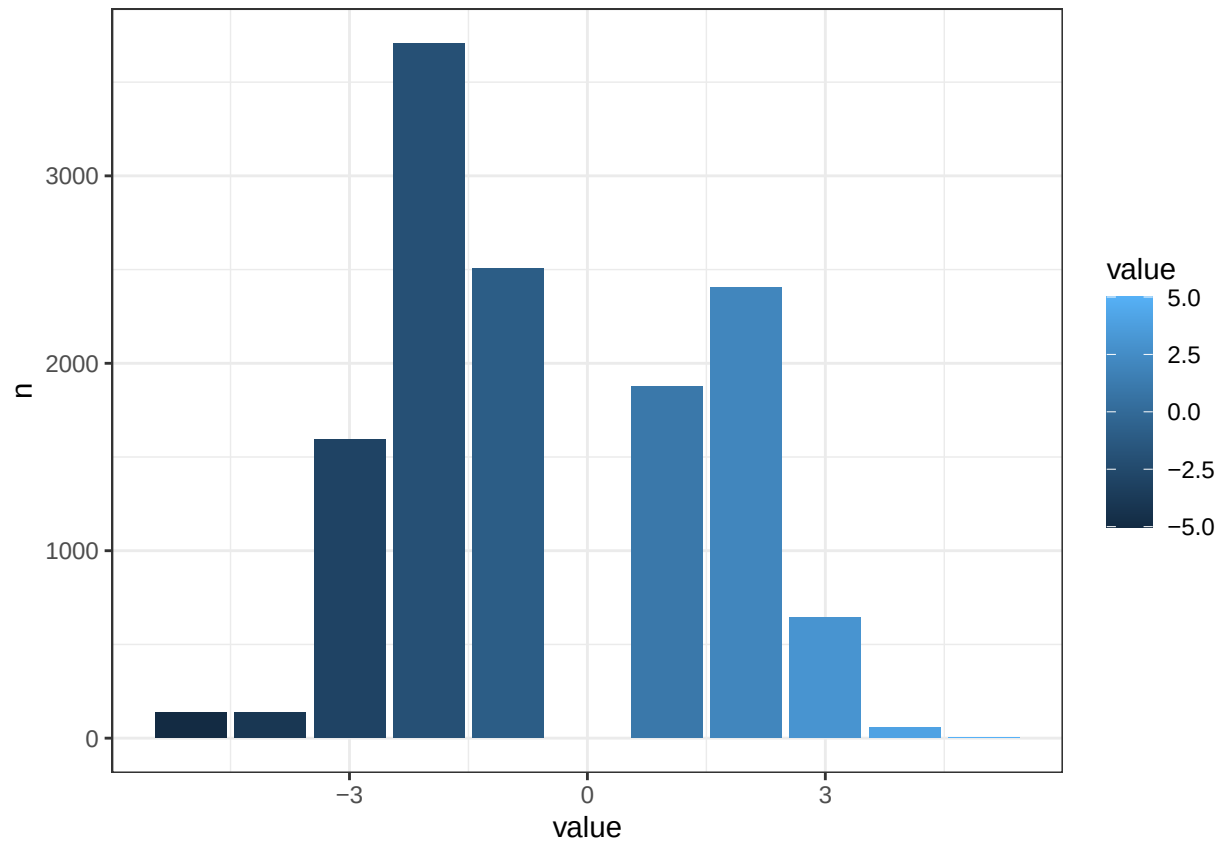
```
## # A tibble: 13,058 x 2  
##   word value  
##   <chr> <dbl>  
## 1 fire    -2  
## 2 dead    -3  
## 3 dead    -3  
## 4 smile    2  
## 5 dead    -3  
## 6 dead    -3  
## 7 dead    -3  
## 8 dead    -3  
## 9 dead    -3  
## 10 drag   -1  
## # i 13,048 more rows
```

*#Now we count these words.*

```
got_afinn_hist <- got_afinn %>%  
  count(value)
```

*#Plot them:*

```
ggplot(data = got_afinn_hist, aes(x = value, y = n)) +  
  geom_col(aes(fill = value)) +  
  theme_bw()
```



Now we can see that the most used value is -2 and there is a general emphasis on negative sentiment in the text.

*#Now we investigate some of the positive words, specifically those rated 2 on the scale.*

```
got_afinn2 <- got_afinn %>%
  filter(value == 2)
```

*#Now we eliminate repetition and focus on unique words.*

```
unique(got_afinn2$word)
```

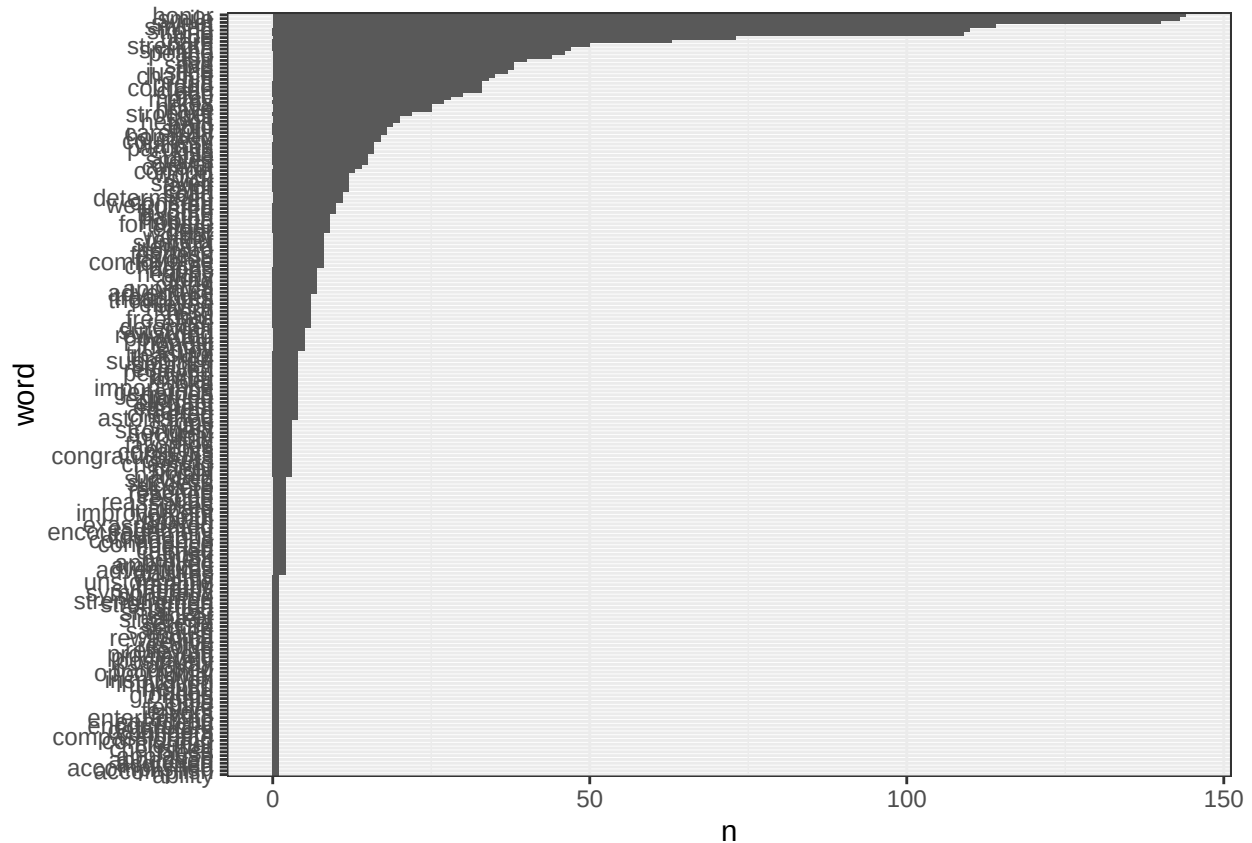
```
## [1] "smile"      "fine"       "glory"      "hope"
## [5] "smiled"    "care"       "strength"   "peaceful"
## [9] "honor"     "carefully"  "slick"      "top"
## [13] "gained"    "comfort"    "sweet"      "courage"
## [17] "daring"    "elegant"    "justice"    "heroes"
## [21] "fair"      "strong"     "brave"      "solid"
## [25] "proud"     "mercy"      "rescue"     "swift"
## [29] "smiling"   "true"       "noble"      "saved"
## [33] "gift"      "treasures"  "favorite"    "clean"
## [37] "rich"      "fearless"  "fortunate"   "likes"
## [41] "earnest"   "generous"   "chances"    "smiles"
## [45] "hug"       "kiss"       "approved"   "fond"
## [49] "honored"   "consent"    "peace"      "powerful"
## [53] "worthy"    "humor"      "entertaining" "save"
```

|          |                   |                 |                 |                |
|----------|-------------------|-----------------|-----------------|----------------|
| ## [57]  | "sincerely"       | "festive"       | "careful"       | "stronger"     |
| ## [61]  | "bold"            | "eager"         | "favored"       | "warmth"       |
| ## [65]  | "pardon"          | "pardons"       | "healthy"       | "loving"       |
| ## [69]  | "chance"          | "thoughtful"    | "enjoy"         | "privileged"   |
| ## [73]  | "positively"      | "stout"         | "encouragement" | "stable"       |
| ## [77]  | "smarter"         | "ease"          | "ambitious"     | "improvement"  |
| ## [81]  | "hopeful"         | "hopes"         | "relieved"      | "helping"      |
| ## [85]  | "cares"           | "importance"    | "favor"         | "tender"       |
| ## [89]  | "welcomed"        | "treasure"      | "spirited"      | "secured"      |
| ## [93]  | "courtesy"        | "calm"          | "resolved"      | "courageous"   |
| ## [97]  | "comfortable"     | "sympathy"      | "reassuring"    | "resolute"     |
| ## [101] | "brisk"           | "appeased"      | "enjoying"      | "hoping"       |
| ## [105] | "intricate"       | "rescued"       | "glorious"      | "adventures"   |
| ## [109] | "friendly"        | "astonished"    | "reward"        | "trusted"      |
| ## [113] | "honest"          | "clever"        | "dear"          | "favors"       |
| ## [117] | "determined"      | "strengthen"    | "approval"      | "slicker"      |
| ## [121] | "sincere"         | "jokes"         | "joke"          | "smartest"     |
| ## [125] | "favorites"       | "hero"          | "adventure"     | "abilities"    |
| ## [129] | "strongest"       | "courteous"     | "exasperated"   | "enjoys"       |
| ## [133] | "rewarded"        | "cherished"     | "comforting"    | "robust"       |
| ## [137] | "cherish"         | "sympathetic"   | "surviving"     | "cheered"      |
| ## [141] | "worth"           | "boldly"        | "acquitted"     | "unstoppable"  |
| ## [145] | "cheer"           | "fervent"       | "applause"      | "cheers"       |
| ## [149] | "proudly"         | "compassionate" | "bless"         | "success"      |
| ## [153] | "supported"       | "kinder"        | "improved"      | "defender"     |
| ## [157] | "tranquil"        | "helpful"       | "hail"          | "tops"         |
| ## [161] | "thankful"        | "calmed"        | "sunshine"      | "opportunity"  |
| ## [165] | "inspiration"     | "survived"      | "gain"          | "freedom"      |
| ## [169] | "growth"          | "futile"        | "swiftly"       | "satisfied"    |
| ## [173] | "congratulations" | "confident"     | "pardoned"      | "energetic"    |
| ## [177] | "esteemed"        | "benefit"       | "secure"        | "accomplished" |
| ## [181] | "support"         | "rewarding"     | "ability"       | "jovial"       |
| ## [185] | "cheering"        | "hailed"        | "playful"       | "confidence"   |
| ## [189] | "consents"        | "bargain"       | "encouraged"    | "relieving"    |
| ## [193] | "accomplish"      | "resolve"       | "cleaner"       | "prominent"    |
| ## [197] | "serene"          | "defenders"     | "strengthened"  | "wealthy"      |
| ## [201] | "revive"          |                 |                 |                |

*#Now we count and plot them.*

```
got_afinn2_n <- got_afinn2 %>%
  count(word, sort = TRUE) %>%
  mutate(word = fct_reorder(factor(word), n))

ggplot(data = got_afinn2_n, aes(x = word, y = n)) +
  geom_col() +
  coord_flip() +
  theme_bw()
```



*#Now we summarize to find the median score of the sentiments.*

```
got_summary <- got_afinn %>%
  summarize(
    mean_score = mean(value),
    median_score = median(value)
  )
got_summary
```

```
## # A tibble: 1 x 2
##   mean_score median_score
##   <dbl>         <dbl>
## 1    -0.542          -1
```

Here we once again see the tendency to have a negative sentiment in the text.

*#Now we will use the ncr function to categorize the text with the feelings  
#they are typically associated to.*

```
got_nrc <- got_stop %>%  
  inner_join(get_sentiments("nrc"))
```

*#Now we use the anti\_join function to check which words were excluded from the text.*

```
got_exclude <- got_stop %>%
```

```

anti_join(get_sentiments("nrc"))

#Now we count the most excluded words.

got_exclude_n <- got_exclude %>%
  count(word, sort = TRUE)

head(got_exclude_n)

```

```

## # A tibble: 6 x 2
##   word      n
##   <chr> <int>
## 1 ser    1023
## 2 jon     787
## 3 ned     743
## 4 tyrion  591
## 5 eyes    567
## 6 hand    567

```

The most excluded word is ‘Ser’ which is the title for knights in the A Song Of Ice And Fire universe. As the story centers around nobility there are a lot of ‘Sers’ in the story, so it frequently shows up.

```

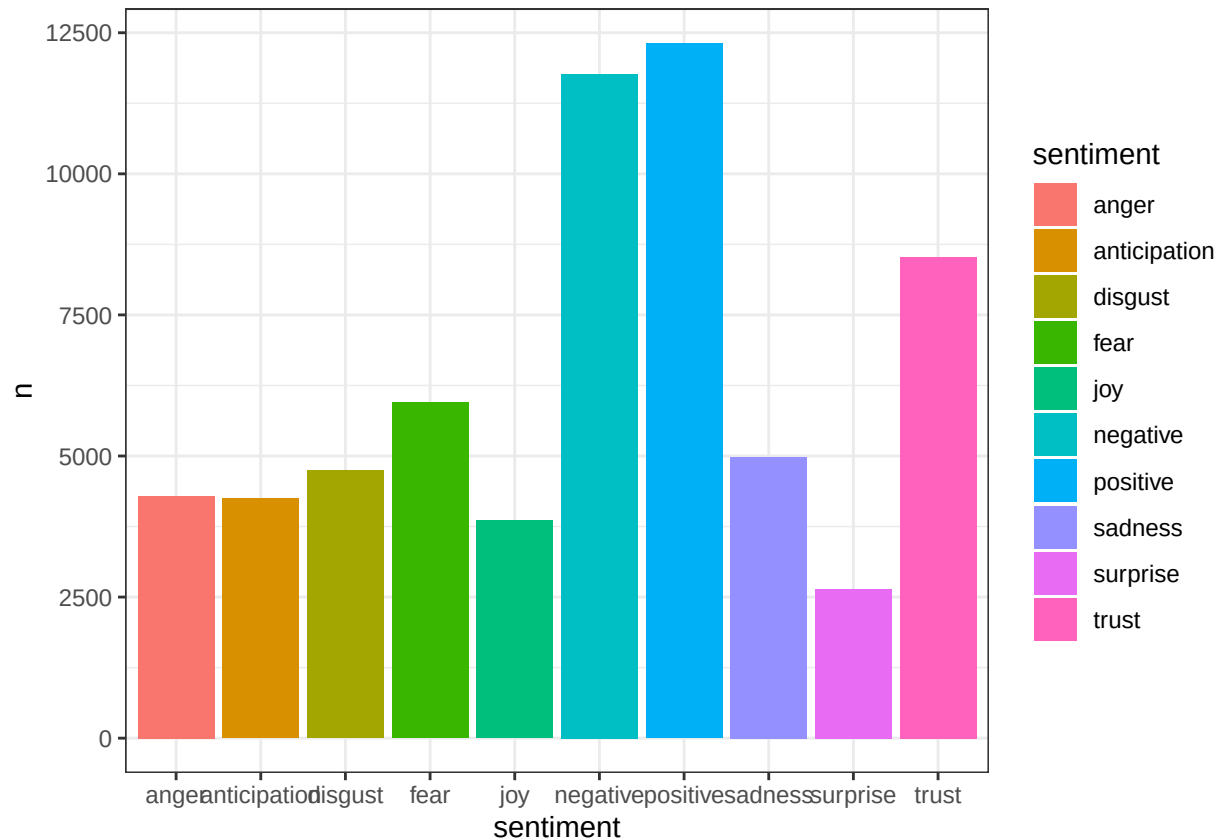
#Now we count the words in their separate sentiments.

got_nrc_n <- got_nrc %>%
  count(sentiment, sort = TRUE)

#And plot them:

ggplot(data = got_nrc_n, aes(x = sentiment, y = n)) +
  geom_col(aes(fill = sentiment))+
  theme_bw()

```



Now we can see the most frequently occurring sentiments, surprisingly this one shows a higher positive outcome.

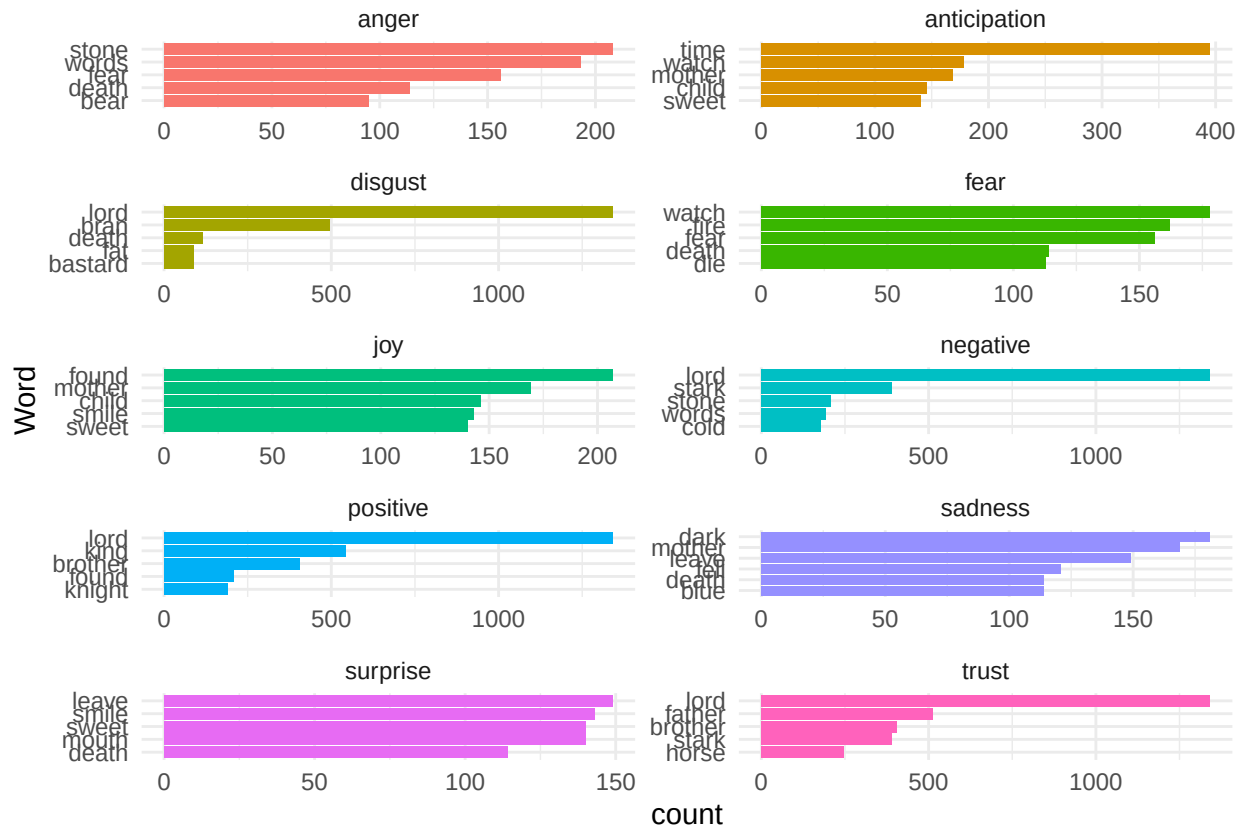
*#Now we combine both word and sentiment.*

```
got_nrc_n5 <- got_nrc %>%
  count(word,sentiment, sort = TRUE) %>%
  group_by(sentiment) %>%
  top_n(5) %>%
  ungroup()
```

```
got_nrc_gg <- ggplot(data = got_nrc_n5, aes(x = reorder(word,n), y = n, fill = sentiment)) +
  geom_col(show.legend = FALSE) +
  facet_wrap(~sentiment, ncol = 2, scales = "free") +
  coord_flip() +
  theme_minimal() +
  labs(x = "Word", y = "count")
```

*#Now we show it.*

```
got_nrc_gg
```



*#And then we save it.*

```
ggsave(plot = got_nrc_gg,
  here("figures", "got_nrc_sentiment.png"),
  height = 8,
  width = 5)
```

This gives us a more detailed overlook of the frequently used words for each sentiment. Now we can find out if there are similarly ambiguous words such as ‘confidence’.

##Are there any terms that are similarly ambiguous to the ‘confidence’ above? In the plot above we can see that the term ‘Lord’ appears as the top in four categories, those being ‘Positive’, ‘Negative’, ‘Trust’ & ‘Disgust’. Making it an ambiguous relation depending on the character relevant in the chapter.

## Answer

GOT is a predominantly negatively connotated text. This is not a surprise as it is a story set in a grimdark medieval fantasy world bereft of justice and fairness. The story centers around the struggles of nobility and the titular ‘Game of Thrones’ that they play. As such there is much focus on the downsides of a feudal system and while the story does have a moral of hope and persevering the majority of the chapters center around something awful happening to someone who, most of the time, deserves it. - However this sentiment analysis might forego looking ‘between the lines’ and thereby miss the greater moral. It is important to not rely solely on the programming alone and be able to understand the context of the story.

## Digital Archives Reflections Assignment

### Part 1

*Explain how Jensen's (2021) category of "digital archival literacy" addresses the distinct challenges digital archives represent for historical research. How has digitization changed historians' interactions with their sources? In your response, focus on two points that you found most thought-provoking. You may also choose to cite Jensen and Schriver (2022) in your response. (250 words)*

The introduction of digital archives and the lack of literacy that many historians have regarding it introduce several challenges. In Jensen's article we are notified that recent work by scholars in Information Science confirms that a majority of historians use these digital research tools, herein mentioned finding aids, search engines, catalogues, etc. However, they fail to consider their impact on methodology. Moreover, as the digitization of sources is funded by investors it tends to favor what is more "popular" or rather in high demand. This can sideline the interests of researchers as we so oft seek to branch out and create new history rather than reiterate on what has already been done. As external funders only want to pay for what is already popular this does introduce a bias in the (sub)-fields of research. However, we now live in a world where using these digital methods are nigh required and it is not necessarily a bad thing. A well-designed archive can mean more accessible resources for all interested. However, we must mention how we used them and why we use them. Failing to do so threatens to make the value and impact of these digital tools invisible and obscured. As knowledge of archives is essential to the work of all historians, no matter the subdiscipline, it is paramount that we understand the internal logic of how an archive is made. This has changed with digital archives and, in some cases, become easier. However, understanding the differences in how an analog archive sorts their sources versus a digital archive will be a much needed skill for those historians wishing to thrive in their chosen fields in this new digitized landscape.

In Jensen's article we are introduced to the difficulties that modern historians can face if they lack digital literacy regarding the newfound tools available to historians. We know now that a majority of historians use digital research tools. The point is made that doing this can have significant impact on methodology, given a risk of lack of proper context. Additionally the points made about the funding coming from investors who largely have an interest in what is 'popular' can be a restricting factor were incredibly interesting if slightly foreboding.<sup>1</sup>

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<sup>1</sup> Helle Strandgaard Jensen (2020): Digital Archival Literacy for (all) Historians, Media History, DOI: 10.1080/13688804.2020.17790

## Part 2

Navigate to the following page entitled “David Boder: from wire recordings to website.” <https://ranke2.uni.lu/u/boder/#c-clip.en>. Familiarize yourself with the page and watch the animation “David Boder's interview collection: from analogue to digital” to learn about Boder’s work and recent efforts to digitize his interviews.

- i. Navigate to <https://iit.aviaryplatform.com/collections/231> and select one of David Boder’s interviews to analyze. Briefly provide the biographical details of the interviewee. After reading the “description” panel, discuss the provenance of the source. For example, what metadata is provided by the archive, and which historical details did the archive choose to emphasize in their written summary of the recording? (250 words)

The interview chosen is “David P. Boder interviews Adolph Heisler, August 27, 1946, Geneva, Switzerland.” In the description given there is a primary focus on Adolph Heisler, the interviewee, and his own experiences. Focus on Heisler’s presumption that the Hungarian officials were most likely major participants in the procedure of ghettoizing the subset of Slovakian Jews that did not get transferred with the majority, which Adolph was a part of. Later he was sent to work in the Jawiszowice coal mine which supplied the factories in Auschwitz. He recalls this being less unbearable than the camps in Germany he was later sent to, despite the hellish conditions. There is a focus on lived experience and the horrors felt firsthand by the interviewee. The website itself provides a transcript with an implemented autoscroll which allows the listener to follow along with the interview even if they do not know the language. It seems from this and the preliminary introductory animation that David P. Boder had a focus on the lived experience of the previously incarcerated he interviewed. Given the time frame especially, this interview in particular only being a year after the end of the war, it makes a lot of sense. The pain was lived but still fresh to those who had lived it. To the more privileged it was as of yet unknown what depravities the prisoners had suffered. It is a narrative driven by the individual. David Boder inquires about specific details of the travails and troubles of the individual, providing a focus on their story over generalizing the pain.

Surveying the metadata shows intricate work done by the designers of the archival website. Written on Javascript it solely focuses on the website itself and seemingly hides no secrets that can shed light on the historical processes used.

- ii. Listen to a few minutes of your chosen interview. Focus on the intonations and emotions expressed by Boder and the interviewee (it’s okay if you do not understand German or Russian). Based on a close listening of the speakers, contemplate how such digitized interviews might provide information absent from text-based interview transcriptions. What are the implications of using

interview recordings as a historical source? You may choose to draw on Presner (2024) or information from the Ranke.2 website in your response. (250 words)

The tone of the interview itself is calm. It is easy to assume that someone who has undergone the horrors of the Nazi regime firsthand would be emotionally charged, yet Adolph Heiser carries himself calmly and explains his story in detail. David Boder carries the interview with a professional tone and asks many clarifying questions that seek to paint a fuller picture. These interviews can provide more than text-based transcriptions alone. Through being able to hear these wire recordings we get a broader sense of the interviewees themselves. Through Adolph Heiser's unshakeable calm we understand more of him as a person. Through hearing these accounts firsthand we are more likely to carry empathy for their pain suffered.

At the same time, the emotional weight of these recordings can also influence the listener's interpretation of the source. Hearing the voice of a survivor creates a far more personal experience than simply reading a written account. In the pauses and hesitation and the tone chosen he communicates emotions and experiences that are difficult to capture through transcript alone. Because of this the recordings function not only as historical documentation but also as individual human testimony.

However, using these interviews as a historical source must be done with critical thinking. The stories of a lone individual seldom speak for an entire people. It must be understood inherently that the interviewee's story is theirs alone and can help broaden an image that must be grounded in macro historical facts. Memory itself can also be imperfect especially when recounting trauma months and years after they occurred. Personal testimony works best when combined with broader historical research.

As is spoken of in Presner's article the concept of "distant witnessing" raises fundamental questions of what ethics are posed regarding testimony when combined with an algorithm.<sup>2</sup>

### **Part 3**

Compare and contrast the use of digitized historical sources in web-based databases with reborn digital sources in the archived Web. Should these sources be treated differently when conducting historical research? To complete this task, draw on your knowledge of at least two database collections discussed in class and/or your readings. In your response, please support your position using relevant literature from our course, such as Kelley (2019), Johnson (2018), Brügger (2019), and the articles mentioned in part one of this assignment. (500 words)

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<sup>2</sup> Keydar, R. (2026). Ethics of algorithm. digital humanities and Holocaust memory: by Todd Presner, Princeton/Oxford, Princeton University Press, 2024, 456 pp., US\$39.95, ISBN 9780691258980. *Journal of Modern Jewish Studies*, 25(1), 136–138. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14725886.2025.2565567>

The historian Niels Brügger argues that using digital sources, whether reborn or born digitally requires a change of methodology. The argument he makes is that a critical viewpoint is required to handle these sources properly on the basis of how digital archives are constructed and curated through technology. Unlike traditional archives, digital archives are not neutral containers of information but systems shaped by preservation choice, metadata structure and software.<sup>3</sup>

Digitized historical sources and reborn digital sources share similarities in that both have gone through processes of selection and categorization. However, they also differ significantly in how historians approach them critically. Databases such as SlaveVoyages.org or the USC Shoah Foundation archive largely consist of historical material that originally existed in analog form before being digitized. These databases provide historians with unprecedented accessibility and the ability to analyze large quantities of data efficiently when paired with programs such as RStudio. In the case of SlaveVoyages, historians can perform quantitative analysis of patterns present in the transatlantic slave trade across centuries in a fraction of the time it would have taken previously.

At the same time, digitization can create an illusion of objectivity. Johnson argues that digital representations of enslaved people risk reducing the dehumanizing logic of slavery itself by reducing human life to numbers and cargo. Structured databases simplify historical complexity into searchable metadata.<sup>4</sup> While this allows for general analysis it can also obscure individual experiences fueled by gaps in the archive. Historians must remain aware that databases are interpretations rather than direct proof of the past.

Reborn digital sources from the archived Web present a different set of challenges. Unlike digitized sources, websites were often born digital and archived retrospectively through services such as Internet Archive's Wayback Machine. Brügger notes that archived websites cannot be understood as exact copies of the live web as it was, but rather as reconstructed images of a bygone past. Subject to selective preservation. Historians using archived web material must study not only the content itself but the archival processes that shaped it.

Ultimately, both digitized historical databases and reborn digital web archives require that historians apply critical thinking in their methodology. However, they should not be treated identically. Digitized databases risk oversimplification of historical experience, while archived web sources raise issues concerning their reconstruction. In both cases

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<sup>3</sup> 1. Niels Brügger and Ian Milligan, eds., *The Archived Web: Doing History in the Digital Age* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2019), Page 4.

<sup>4</sup> 4 Johnson, Jessica Marie. "Markup Bodies: Black [Life] Studies and Slavery [Death] Studies at the Digital Crossroads." *Social Text* 36, no. 4 (December 1, 2018): page 60

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historians must critically examine not only the content of the source itself but also the digital systems through which it has been preserved, structured and made accessible.